

Design Thinking for UX Designer



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ACTIVITY

**What's one moment you
struggled when starting a
new initiative?**

Issues We're Facing



You're only designing based on requirements from Business Owner, Stakeholder or Partner



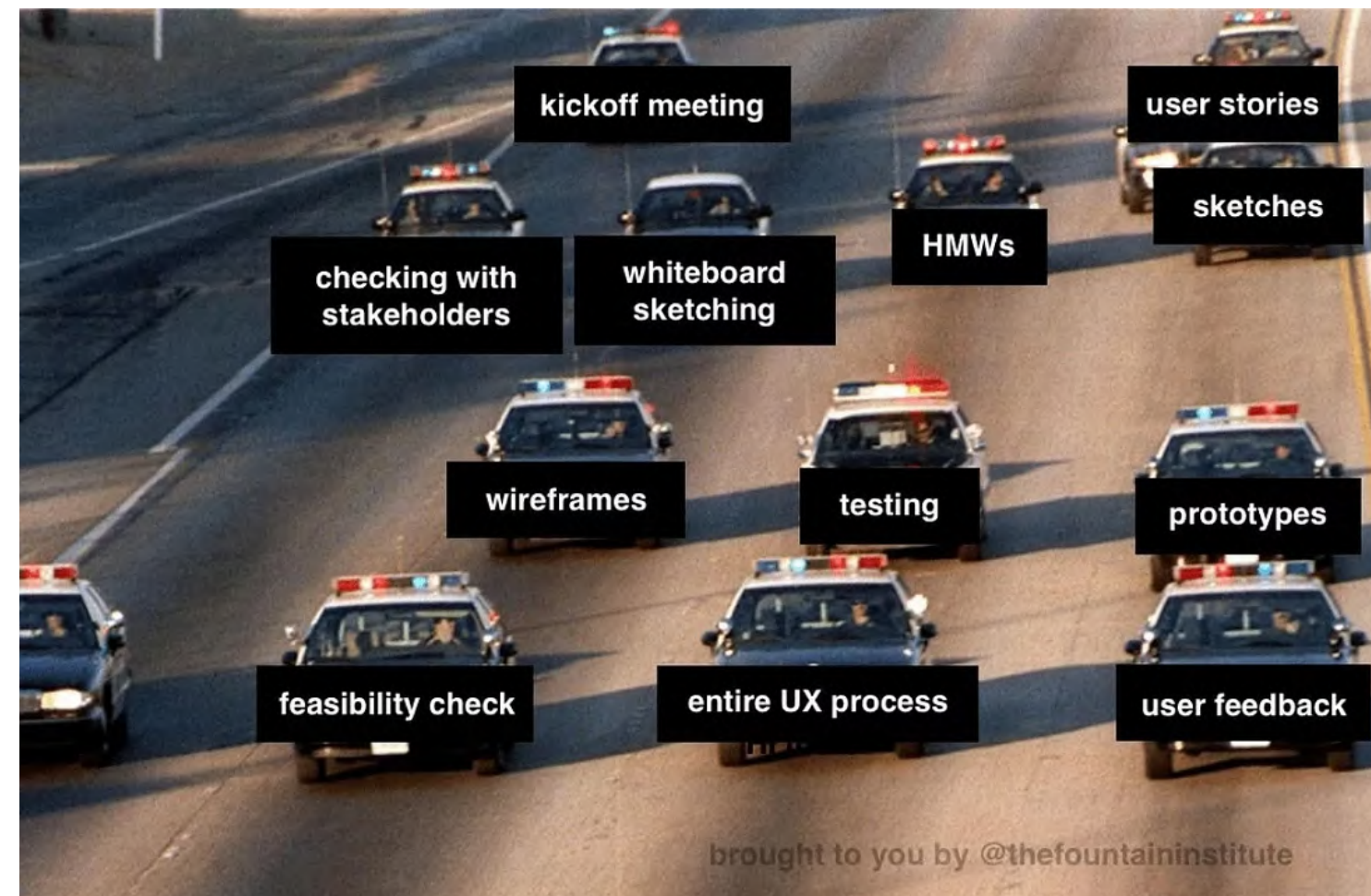
You jump into high-fidelity design very quickly when you receive a request from another party



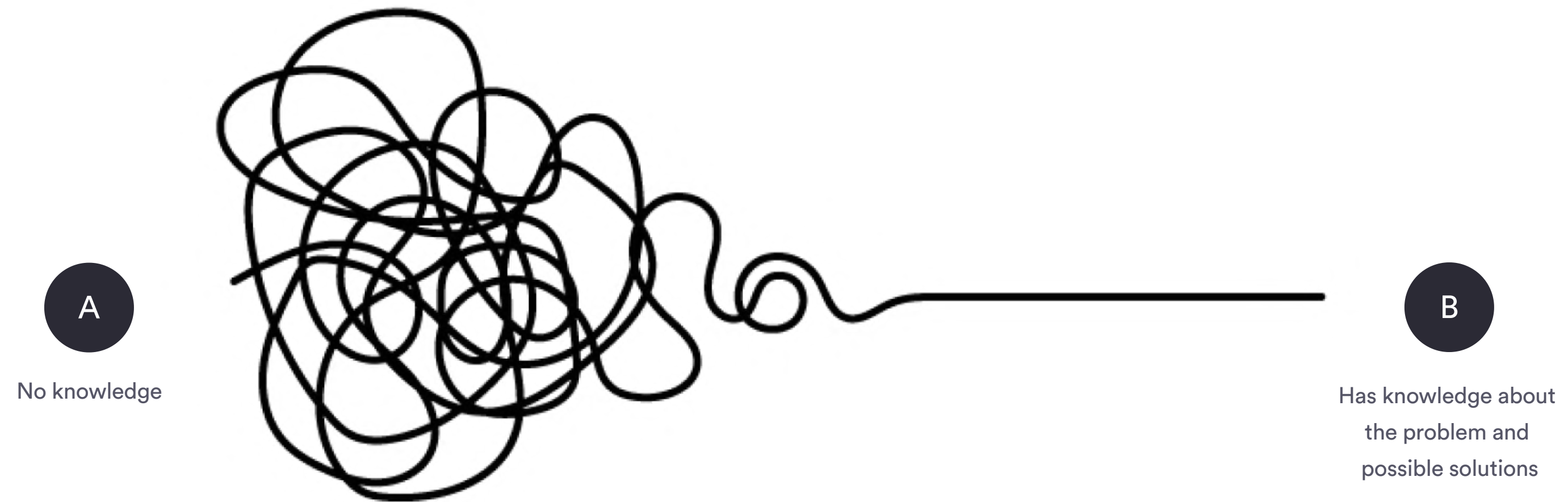
You're only working alone and losing connection with people outside your team

But does it really make the people happy?

People not recognizing what a UX designer actually does...



Source image



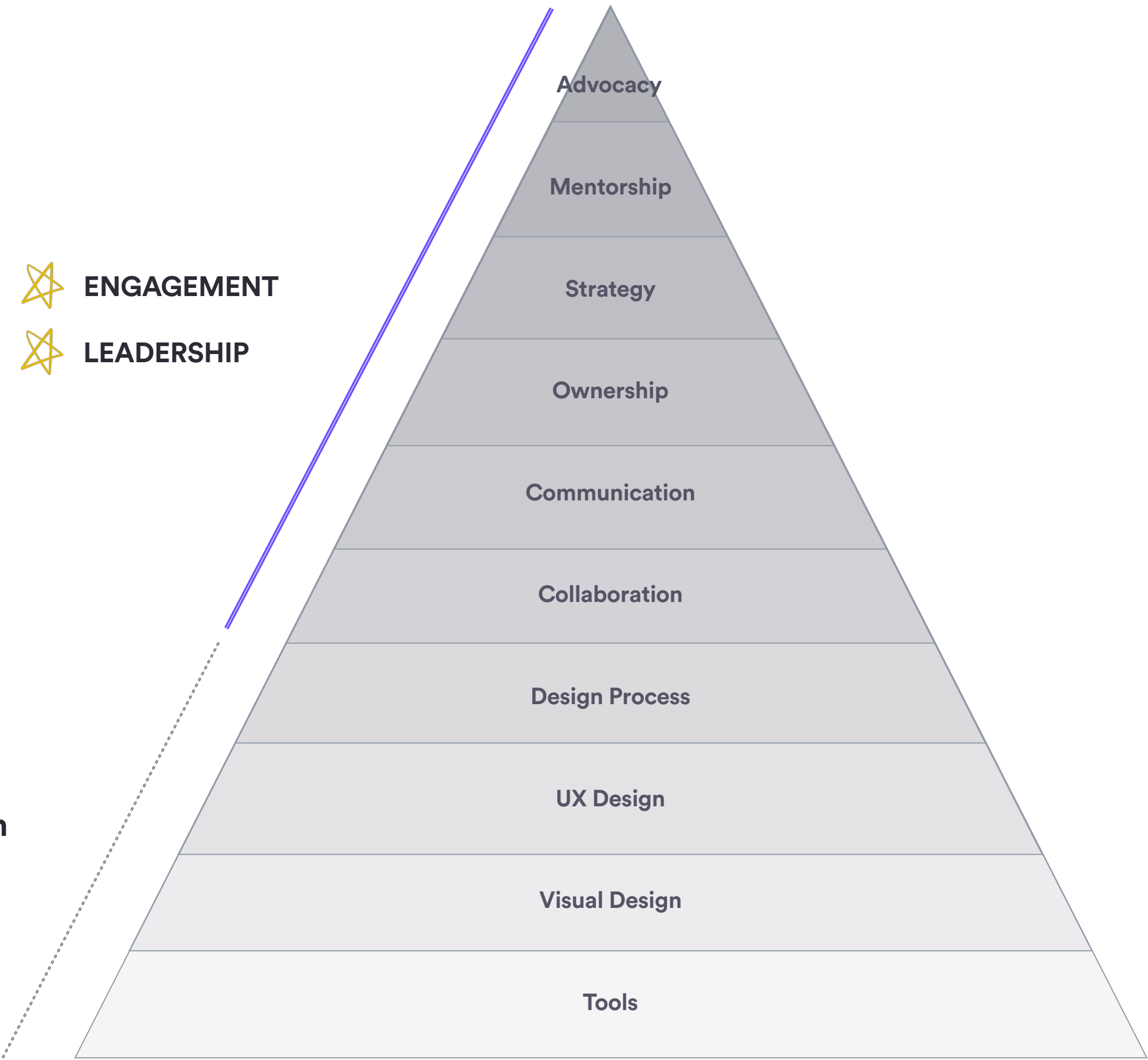
***"The problem is not lack of design skill.
It's lack of design thinking"***

Theory

What is Design Thinking

Design Thinking

is a human-centered problem-solving method that helps teams understand user needs, challenge assumptions, and create innovative solutions.



90% of
dicussion

★ ENGAGEMENT
★ LEADERSHIP

Tháp năng lực của Product Designer

@Artiom Dashinsky

Why design fails without a process

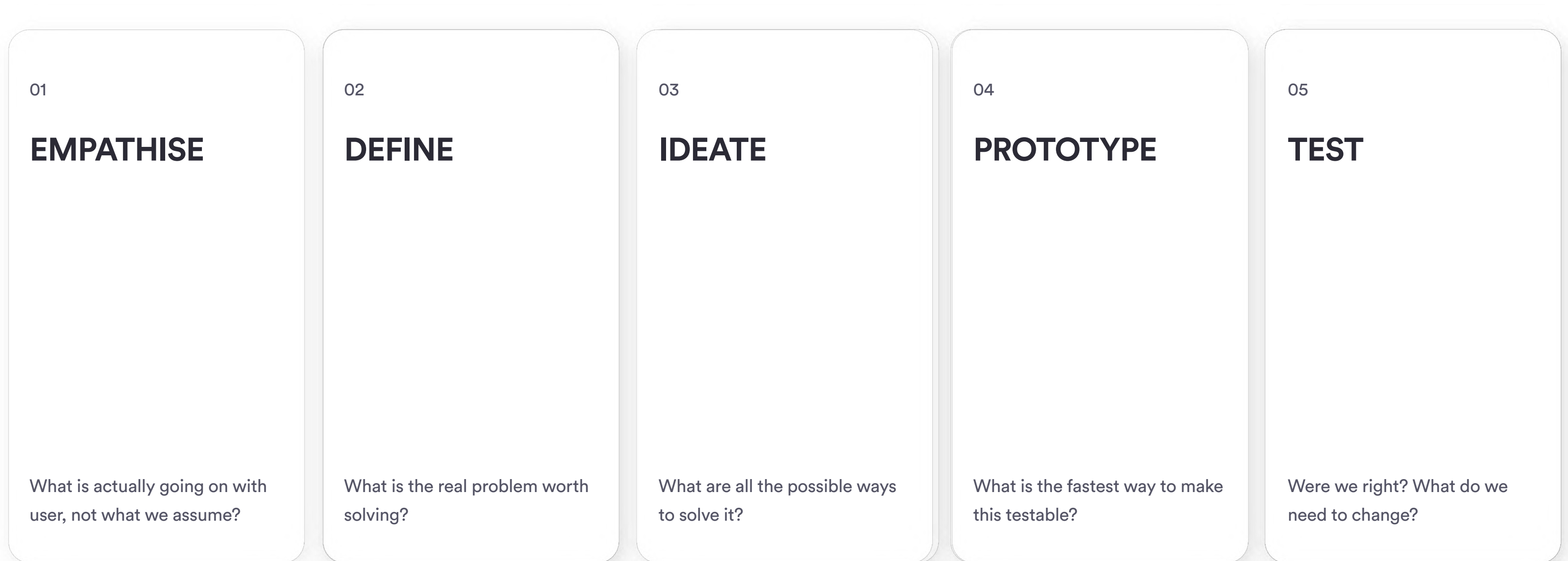
WITHOUT DESIGN PROCESS

- Solution decided before problem is understood
- Brief treated as truth — never questioned
- Assumptions invisible until it's too late
- Late pivots, expensive rework, frustrated teams

WITH DESIGN PROCESS

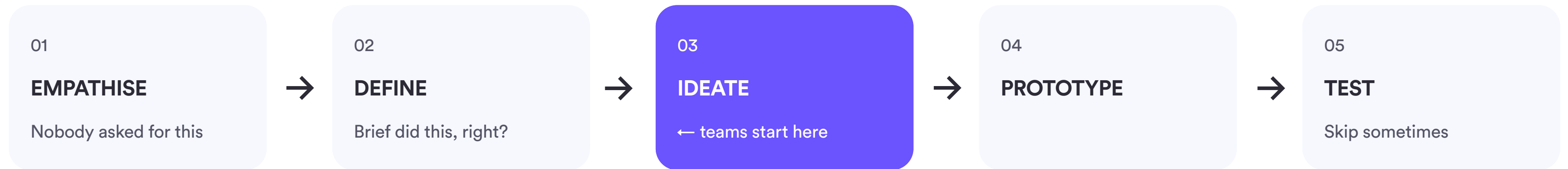
- Decisions grounded in user evidence
- Assumptions surfaced before they cause damage
- Research that actually changes what gets built
- Fewer surprises at launch

The 5-Stage Cycle



Non-linear: move freely between stages as insights emerge

The pattern most teams follow



ISSUE

"A brief is not a problem definition."

Empathise and Define aren't skipped because designers don't know them.

*They're skipped **because nobody asked for them.***

What good process looks like?

01

Understand users first

Research Brief · Interviews · Assumption Map

03

Organise for users

Evidence-based sitemap · Task flows

05

Find out if you were right

Test synthesis · Iterated prototype

02

Frame the real problem

Insight statements · Problem statement · JTBD

04

Build to answer questions

Wireframes · Prototype · Decision Log

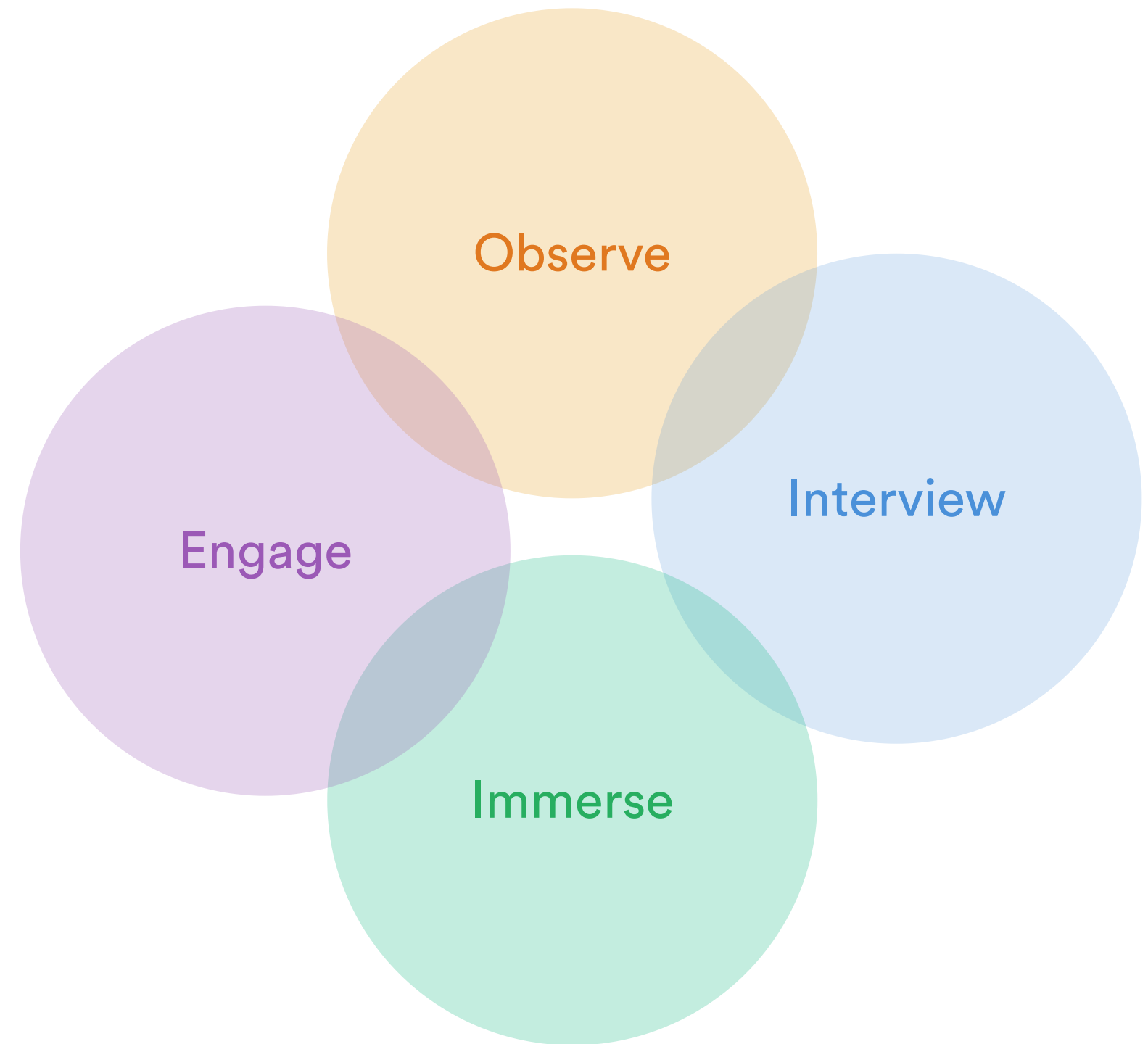
Stage 1

EMPATHISE

Try Pitch

The Empathise stage is the very first step in the design thinking process.

It's all about deeply understanding the people you're designing for, not just their actions, but their feelings, motivations, and pain points.



Stage 1

Discovery Activities

Understand users, their context, and their real experience before any solution thinking begins.



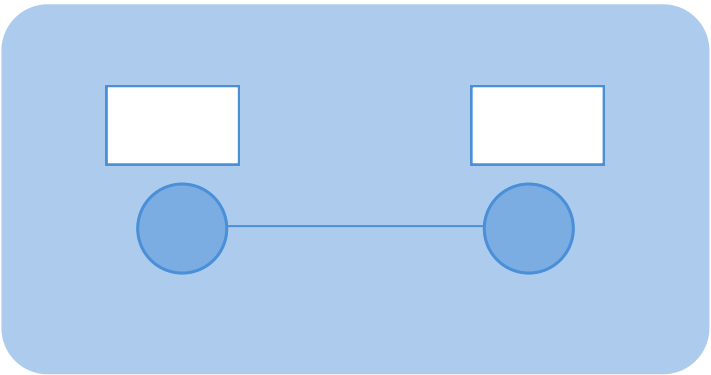
Desk research

Competitor review, market reports, analytics, existing research. Done before primary research to avoid re-learning what's known.



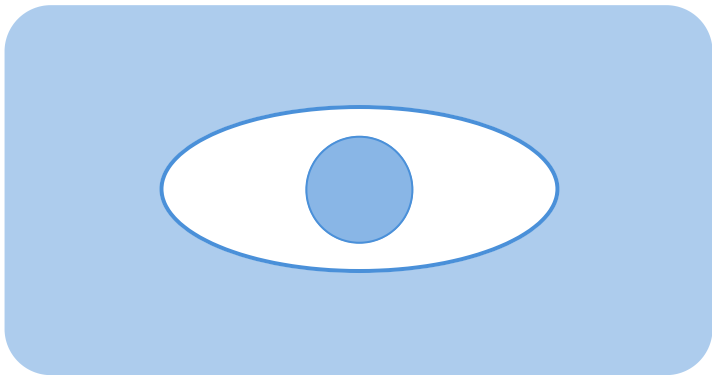
User survey

quantitative snapshot. Good for scale, bad for understanding. Supplement interviews, don't replace them



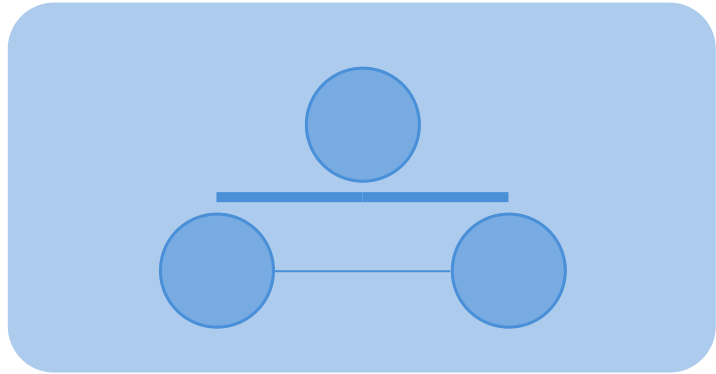
User interviews

Open questions, probing techniques, avoiding leading language.



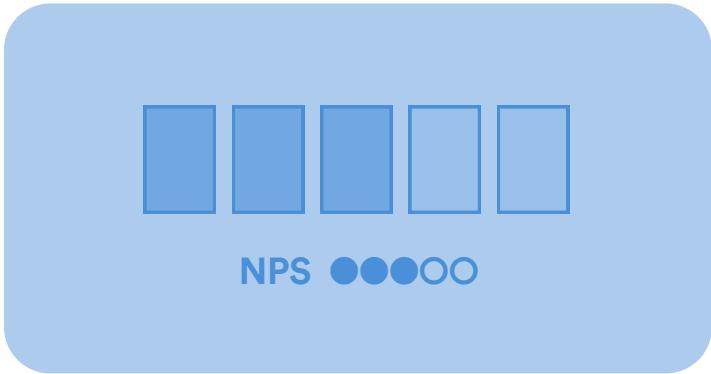
Shadowing observation

Observe without interfering. Surface the workarounds and habits users don't think to mention.



Stakeholder interviews

Understand business context, constraints, and assumptions. Not a substitute for user research.



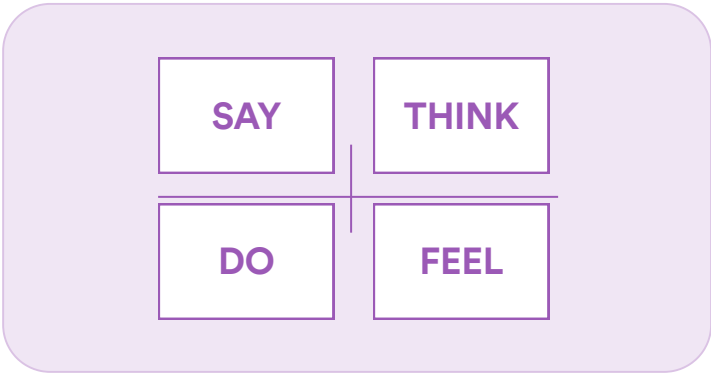
Support ticket / NPS analysis

What are users already saying? Mine for patterns before talking to users directly.

Stage 1

Synthesis Activities

A visual of all insights into a clear story



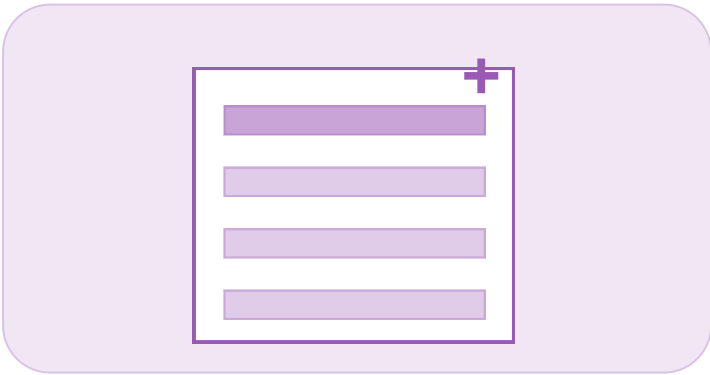
Empathy mapping

What users say, think, do, and feel.
Forces you to distinguish observation from inference.



Assumption Map

For every session, move entries from Unknown to Confirmed or Unconfirmed.



Research Log update

Add an entry after every user conversation — quote, behaviour, context.



Stage 2 - Define

**What is the real problem
worth solving?**



Market Research Process

-  Problem Definition
-  Approach Formulation
-  Research Design Selection
-  Data Collection
-  Data Processing
-  Analysis & Reporting

Research Designs

- Secondary
- Primary
- Exploratory
- Descriptive
- Causal

Data Collection, Processing & Analysis

- Qualitative
- Quantitative

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Insights & Business Implications

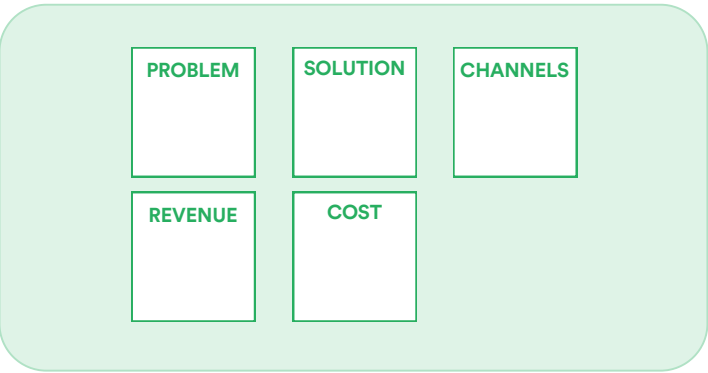


Relevant Insights, LLC

DEFINE

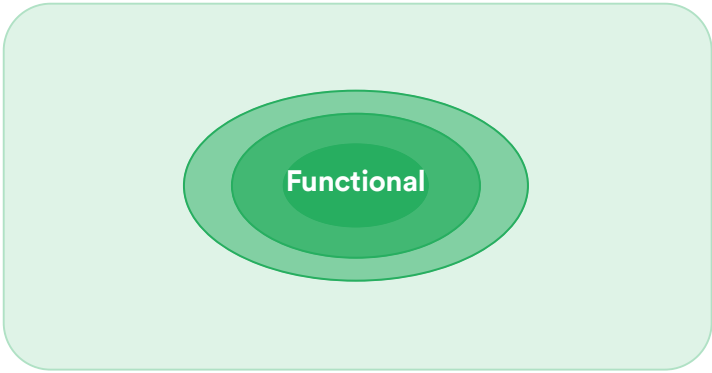
Define

Turn raw research into a clear, validated problem statement the whole team can align on and design against.



Lean UX Canvas

Observe without interfering. Surface the workarounds and habits users don't think to mention.



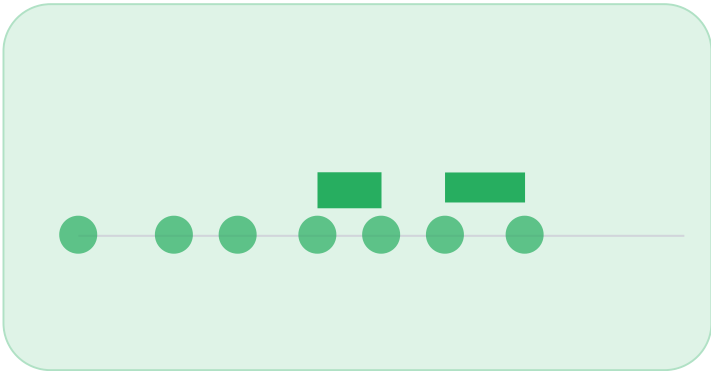
Jobs-to-Be-Done mapping

Functional (task), emotional (feeling), and social (perception) jobs. Most design misses target emotional and social jobs.



How Might We (HMW)

Convert each insight into a design opportunity question. "How might we...?" Not too broad (unsolvable) and not too narrow (already a solution).



Current-state journey mapping

Map the experience as it actually is, not as it should be

“

**People don't know what they want
until you show it to them.**



Steve Jobs

The founder and former CEO of Apple

Stage 3

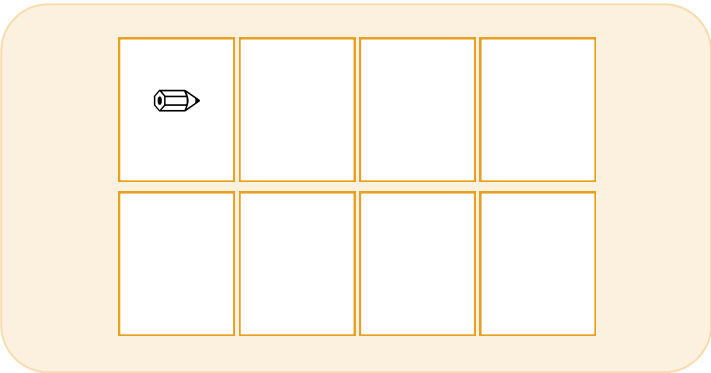
Ideate

Try Pitch

Stage 3

Generate activities

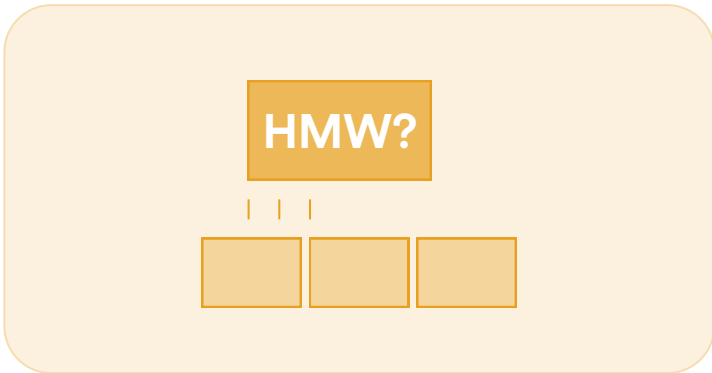
Explore as many possible solutions as possible before committing to one. Quantity first, quality later



Crazy 8s

8 sketches in 8 minutes. Forces volume, kills perfectionism. No filtering allowed during generation.

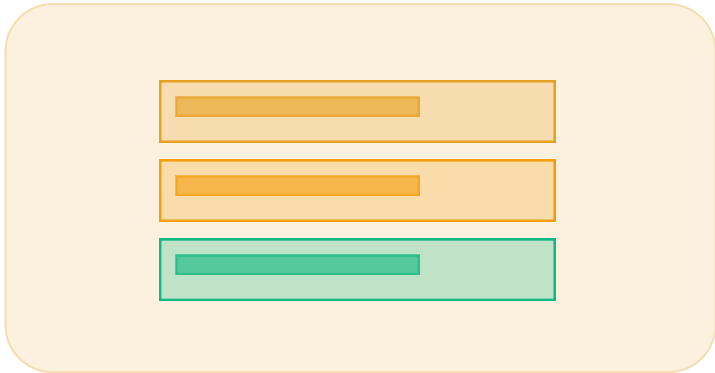
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HMW ideation

Take each HMW question and generate 5–10 ideas against it. The question is the constraint that makes ideas useful.

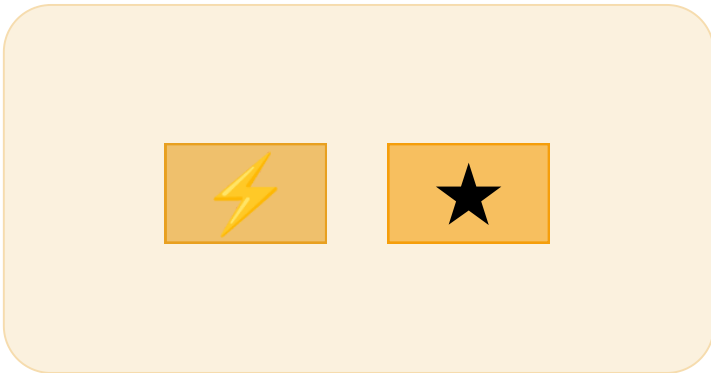
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Brainwriting

Silent, parallel idea generation in writing. Prevents groupthink and loudest-voice bias.

=



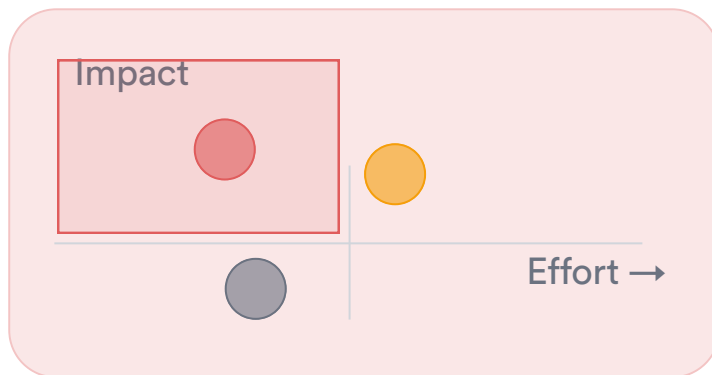
Ideate Workshop

Run Crazy 8s + HMW Ideation back-to-back in a 30-min sprint. Together they give you 50+ ideas to dot-vote from.

Stage 3

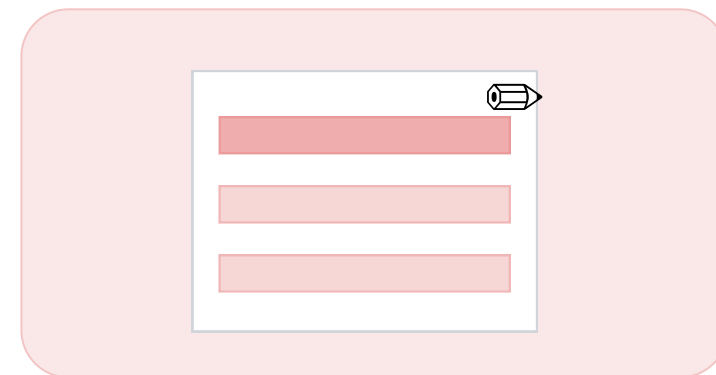
Select activities

You have explored multiple directions — not just one.



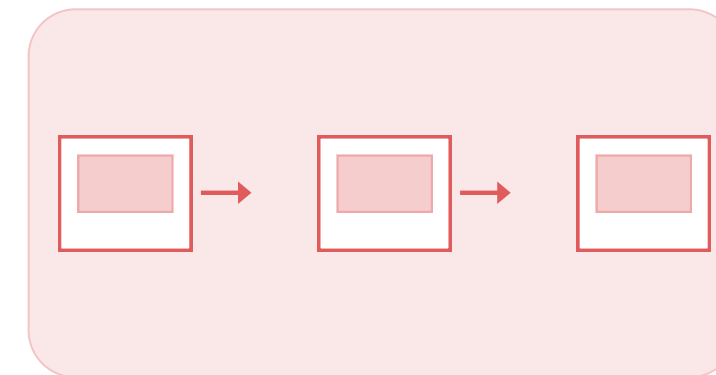
Impact vs effort matrix

Plot ideas by impact (user value) vs effort (build cost). Focus on top-left quadrant



Concept sketching

Develop the top 2–3 directions into fuller sketches with a narrative



Storyboarding

Narrative of how the concept plays out for a user in their real context.



Proposed process map

Map the experience as it should feel after your solution is built. Identifies where the prototype must take the user.

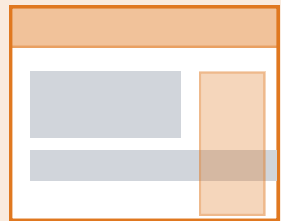
Stage 4

Prototype

Try Pitch

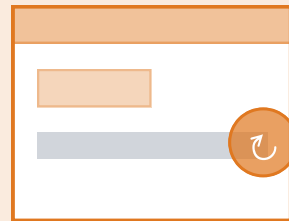
Stage 4

Prototype



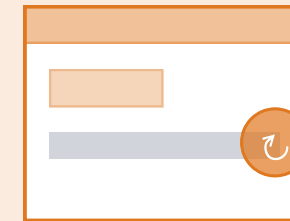
Wireframes

Structural layout showing content hierarchy and interaction patterns. No colour, no brand, no distraction.



Interactive prototype

States, transitions, navigation demos. Cover key interaction states: default, loading, empty, error, success.



POC (Proof of concepts)

Answers one question: does this idea actually work? Keep it rough, keep it fast. You're not building a product yet — you're building an argument

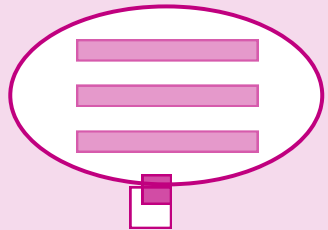
Stage 5

Test

Testing

Testing Session

Find out if the design solves the problem — and change what doesn't based on evidence.



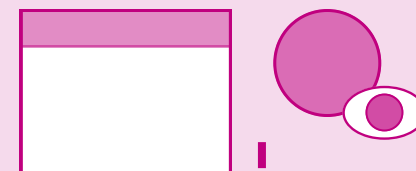
Internal feedback session

Structured critique using 'I noticed / I wonder / What if' — not 'I like / I don't like.' Documents decisions before shipping.



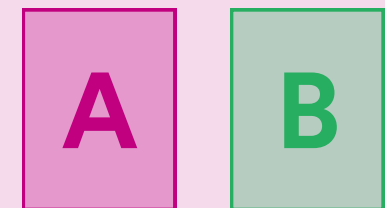
Concept testing

Show a concept (not a working prototype) to 3 users. Measure comprehension: do they understand what it is and why it would be useful?



Moderated/Unmoderated usability testing

Facilitator observes user completing real tasks live. Think-aloud protocol. 5 users reveals ~85% of critical issues.



A/B testing

Compare two live versions with real traffic. Answers 'which is better?' not 'why.' Use after qualitative research has shaped the variants.

Activity: Set up design process

Draft your Design Process

Use your real project. One step at a time

EMPATHISE	DEFINE	IDEATE	PROTOTYPE	TEST
Activity	Activity	Activity	Activity	Activity
Activity	Activity	Activity	Activity	Activity
Activity	Activity	Activity	Activity	Activity

 AI in Practice - Paste this prompt into AI Tools:

I'm a UX designer working on [project description]. My users are [who they are]. Current stage: [stage]. Key assumptions from my brief audit: [paste list].

Generate a Design Process overview. For each DT stage:

- 1. What should I do for this specific project?*
- 2. What outputs should I produce?*
- 3. What tells me it's safe to move forward?*
- 4. What's the biggest risk if I skip this stage?*

What to Do Before Next Session

Set up design process

- Choose a real project
- Set up activities based on Design Thinking
- Use a management tool such as Jira, Project Planner, Notion, ...
- Share back with your team and agree on a shared workspace

<https://www.figma.com/board/hsOlPhjOgyDe276NCH5oLS/Anh-Truong-s-Board?node-id=14-3265&t=NarSDH3ys9NYdLe1-4>

AI in Practice - Paste this prompt into AI Tools:

"I'm a UX designer starting a project: [describe your project in 1–2 sentences]. My users are [who they are]. Help me map out a Design Thinking process for this project. For each stage (Empathise, Define, Ideate, Prototype, Test), suggest: 1 key activity, 1 output to produce, and 1 sign that I'm ready to move to the next stage."

Complete the design brief

- Open your Design Brief in Notion — it's already waiting for you
- Fill in what you know right now - **don't wait to have all the answers**
 - Write a first draft of your Problem Statement
 - Describe your primary user in 2–3 sentences
 - List 3 design goals
 - Note any constraints you already know about
- After your stakeholder interview (Assignment 3) — come back and update it

AI in Practice - Paste this prompt into AI Tools:

"I'm a UX designer working on [describe your project in 1–2 sentences]. My users are [who they are]. I'm writing a design brief and I want to draft a Problem Statement using this structure: [User] needs a way to [do something] because [pain point], which results in [negative outcome]. Help me write 3 versions — one broad, one specific, one from a business perspective. Then tell me which one you think is strongest and why."

Capture current screens

- For each main experience in your project, capture the current screen flow as it exists today
- Identify the key experiences to map (e.g. Onboarding, Core Task, Checkout, Settings)
- Screenshot each screen in the flow — aim for a high-level overview, not every micro-state
- Arrange in a screen flow layout (like the example above) — label each screen with its state
- We will use these flows in the next session to set up friction metrics for each step

Run Stakeholder Interview

- Choose a real project
- Run 1 stakeholder interview (Clients, SMEs, PO, Engineering, etc.)
 - Prepare the session outcome (Current user experience + current pain points)
 - Prepare a script and questions for the stakeholder interview
 - Ask for a recording (Optional)
 - Note taking
 - Share back findings
 - Update design brief

AI in Practice - Paste this prompt into AI Tools:

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Generate a Design Process overview. For each DT stage:

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